

The Rot Within

getting a monthly salary of Rs 3,000 or even less, which is not equivalent to that of a NREGA labourer," says a female coach at the K.D. Singh Babu Stadium in Lucknow.

This is what happens when sporting bodies are administered by people who have neither professional experience nor interest in the sport. Rajneesh Mishra, former international hockey player, says, "No, they are not criminals, but behave like them. Most of them have grabbed different sports associations and have coiled over there for decades by manipulating the so-called elections in their favour."

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SPORTS COLLEGE, LUCKNOW: ATHLETES DORM (ABOVE); DECAYED STADIUM (LEFT); MURKY POOL WATERS (EXTREME LEFT)

Most such associations in the state are controlled by a particular kind of sports administrator. No matter what, the post has to stay within the family. So if father was the president or the secretary of the association, when he retires, his son will succeed him. Like it happened in the case of the Uttar Pradesh Swimming Association where after K.N. Kapoor retired as the secretary, his son Robin Kapoor took over.

The state Government has more or less been a mute spectator to all this. "What can we do if they are not holding elections and some people have grabbed the associations for decades now?" says Hari Om, director of the state Sports Department. He should ask M.S. Gill.

by Subhash Mishra

limiting the tenure. The guideline states that federation presidents can serve 12 years, and secretaries and treasurers two terms of four years each, and an age cap of 70.

Between the officials in that room were more than 200 collective years of sports administration but only 18 Olympic medals (including 11 in hockey, which was last earned in 1980). By their account what was under threat by a 'draconian law' was their 'autonomy' and India's Olympic existence.

"We will not accept this financial blackmail," thundered one. Jagdish Tytler, head of the Judo Federation of India, said plaintively that honorary officials like his brethren around him were "spending our time and leaving our businesses to be involved in sport". Badminton's V.K. Verma said "there is total transparency in Indian sports federations" and that the Federation raised five times the money "than what the Government provided".

The ministry is not quaking in its boots. A senior official would head to the Olympic headquarters in Lausanne to discuss the issue there. Singh is undeterred, "They are planning a fruitless trip. The IOC will welcome them but they're not going to change the Olympic charter or make special concessions for India."

The Ministry cites the IOC's executive board rules which have tenure and age limits on its office-bearers as an example of "best practice" that India needs to follow. Tenure limits were, a statement said, "widely prevalent and internationally accepted; and is also one of the critical ingredients of good governance".

Singh says all national sports federations have different rules. Insisting India follow what is actually an "IOC election process" is just a step on the road to "get India suspended from the Olympic movement".

Depending which side you are on this could be a sound argument or mere semantics. The athletes are baffled. "Isn't 10 years a long time? What do these guys want? To be reincarnated in the same office? To have 10 lives?" asked one Olympian.

If this was a popularity contest, then none of the officials in that room would have been able to win a vote from a current athlete, be it Kalmadi or archery's Vijay Kumar Malhotra, now inching close to four decades in office. The outspoken former world billiards champion Michael Ferreira says, "This churning is necessary in Indian sport. Progress requires change—you need people with new ideas, fresh ideas, guys with get-up-and-go. Otherwise you get fossilised. I find this pathetic clinging to power absolutely amazing." The clinging is to 'honorary' posts, what should actually be considered thankless jobs. That

INDIAN SPORTS BOSSES PREFER TO SPEND ON CEREMONIES, NOT COACHING

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Officials have to perform themselves and try to egg on and bring up athletes. That's not happening in most of our sports.



ABHINAV BINDRA, Olympic champ